

Siyaraj

A 2D pixel-art platformer where Siya rescues Raj with Diwali fireworks, and her best friend is the final boss.

Team

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The pitch

Diwali is one night away and Swaminathan has kidnapped Raj. Siya, a fireworks maker's daughter, grabs the family stock and goes after him. A small bird called Robin tags along. Robin spots hazards, explains new tricks and pecks at enemies. Raj is no help. He poses dramatically in his cell and sulks about being the only clean-shaven hero in the story.

The game is a short, linear side-scroller in the spirit of Guacamelee. We borrow its folk-art world, its fast combat and its habit of not taking itself seriously, and we swap Mexican folk art for Indian folk art. The world uses rangoli borders, truck-art colors and Madhubani patterns. The target length is 10 to 15 minutes.

How the game uses the three themes

Theme	Where it shows up
Comic	Cutscenes play as static comic panels with speech bubbles. Hits pop up as "BOOM!" and "ZAP!" in Devanagari-style lettering. Robin comments on everything. Swaminathan and his guards twirl their moustaches before a big attack, and Siya twirls hers to charge her special.
Twist	The story flips the rescue, so the girl saves the guy. The real twist comes in the last fight. Swaminathan hypnotises Robin, and Siya has to fight the bird that has been helping her all game. She does not want to hurt him, so she has to knock him out without a killing blow. Once he wakes up, he fights beside her against Swaminathan, and then he does something nobody expects.
Light	Fireworks are the only weapons and the only way across gaps. Level 2 is dark, and Siya relights diyas that act as checkpoints. The last level is the fully lit Diwali celebration.

Story in four beats

- **Setup.** Raj is taken from the ghats on the eve of Diwali. Siya and Robin find a trail of burnt-out sparklers.
- **Chase.** They cross the ghats and a dark forest. Robin teaches her each new move as she needs it, and Siya relights diyas along the way.
- **Twist.** In Swaminathan's hall, he hypnotises Robin and turns him on Siya. She fights him with pulled punches and a lot of shouting.
- **Finale.** Robin wakes up and joins the fight. To finish Swaminathan, Robin dives straight into him. There is a flash, and the two fuse into one flapping creature called Nathan Robin, who flies off into the sunset. Siya frees Raj and the palace lights up with fireworks.

Gameplay

We are building one hook and building it well. Fireworks are both movement and combat. Guacamelee works because the controls feel good, so the first two days go to getting that right.

Move	Firework	What it does
Run and jump	None	Base movement with a short coyote-time window to keep jumps forgiving.
Rocket dash	Rocket	Fast horizontal dash. Crosses gaps and breaks weak walls.
Sparkler whip	Sparkler	The main melee attack, with a short combo chain.
Anar slam	Anar fountain	Ground pound that launches nearby enemies upward.
Moustache special	Chakri	Hold to twirl and charge. Release for a spinning area attack.
Robin strike	Dropped sparks	Sends Robin to hit the nearest enemy, then he returns. Short cooldown. Robin also shows up beside new hazards with a hint.

Levels and boss

Stage	Setting	Focus
1. The ghats	River steps and temples at dusk	Teaches run, jump, dash and the sparkler whip. Robin gives the hints.
2. The forest	Dark forest with diya checkpoints	Introduces the anar slam, a shielded enemy and Robin strike.
3. Swaminathan's palace	Gold hall with fireworks everywhere	Uses every move and ends with the three-part boss fight.

Boss, part 1, Swaminathan. He twirls his moustache before each big attack, which gives the player a clear tell. After a few hits he hypnotises Robin and the fight changes. **Part 2, Robin.** Robin dives, swoops and drops sparks, using the same attacks he used for Siya, so the player knows every pattern. Siya has no lethal option. Her moves fill a dizzy meter, and when it is full Robin drops from the air. The dialogue and the music make clear she hates doing it. **Part 3, together.** Robin wakes up, and for the first time the player controls both. They burn the moustache with a combined firework and Swaminathan goes into a faster, angrier phase. To end it, Robin dives into him, they fuse into Nathan Robin and flap away, arguing with themselves. Enemies elsewhere are palette and behavior swaps of two base sprites.

Art and audio

Pixel art in a folk-art palette of hot pink, turquoise and marigold, with two parallax layers and one tileset per level. Music is dhol and shehnai over chiptune. Robin needs one sprite sheet that covers flying, attacking, the hypnotised eyes and the dizzy fall.

Plan for 100 hours

Phase	Share	Goal
Prototype	30%	Siya with run, jump, dash and one enemy in grey boxes. Movement must feel good before anything else.
Production	40%	Final art, three levels, enemies, Robin and the boss fight, built in parallel by artists and programmers.
Polish	20%	Comic cutscenes, music, sound, menus and the Diwali ending.
Submit	10%	Bug fixes and the build. No new features.

If we run behind, we cut in this order. First the diya darkness effect, then the extra enemy type, then Robin strike during levels, which leaves him as a guide only. **If we run ahead,** we add a second special and more comic gags. The firework dash, the Robin fight and the lit-up ending stay in no matter what.